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Original Clinical Goal: Design a stimulus control and sleep hygiene routine for sleep-onset insomnia

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Stimulus Control and Sleep Hygiene Protocol for Sleep-Onset Insomnia

Introduction

This evidence-based Cognitive Behavioral Therapy for Insomnia (CBT-I) protocol is designed for adults experiencing difficulty initiating sleep. Stimulus control strengthens the conditioned association between the bed and rapid sleep onset, while sleep hygiene optimizes physiological readiness for rest.

Goals

- Re-establish the bed and bedroom as strong discriminative stimuli for sleep rather than frustration or alertness.
- Maintain a consistent sleep-wake schedule to consolidate homeostatic sleep drive.
- Eliminate sleep-incompatible autonomic arousal in the bedroom.

Step-by-Step Instructions

Step 1: The 20-Minute Re-Association Rule

Go to bed only when genuinely sleepy. If you have not fallen asleep within approximately 20 minutes:

- Leave the bedroom immediately.
- Move to a dimly lit room and engage in a quiet, non-screen activity (e.g., reading a physical book, gentle somatic relaxation).
- Return to bed only when drowsiness returns. Repeat as often as necessary throughout the night.

Step 2: Bedroom Exclusivity

Do not use the bed for any activities other than sleep and sexual intimacy. Reading, watching television, checking phones, eating, or working must occur outside the bedroom.

Step 3: Anchor Wake Time

Set a non-negotiable wake-up time 7 days a week, regardless of how much sleep you obtained the previous night. Do not compensate with daytime naps.

Practice and Homework

- Keep a 7-day sleep diary recording bed time, estimated sleep onset latency, night awakenings, and final rising time.
- Implement the 20-minute rule consistently every night for the upcoming 14 days without exception.

Reflection and Progress Review

- Did you notice any anticipatory anxiety when getting into bed?
- How many times did you leave the bedroom before sleep onset occurred?
- What calming activity proved most effective during the out-of-bed interval?

Conclusion

Conditioned insomnia develops gradually and requires 2-4 weeks of consistent behavioral practice to extinguish. If insomnia symptoms persist beyond 4 weeks or if daytime impairment impairs safety, consult a licensed clinical psychologist or sleep medicine physician for personalized care.